

Abraham Romero Torres

EDCI 7334 — Week 2 Reflection

Spring 2024

What are Historical Curricular-Pedagogical Languages (CPP), and from these languages, what should we retain?

Reflecting upon the different historical curricular-pedagogical languages and what we should retain from these forced me to confront my own biases and examine the way I teach mathematics to students. My exploration of traditionalist teaching approaches highlighted the belief that "to be a great teacher one must know and love one's subject. Too many educators lack a deep appreciation and understanding of their discipline" (Schubert, 1990, p. 170). Additionally, I noted that from the Social Behaviorist perspective, it is crucial to prioritize knowledge that serves practical purposes, particularly in our rapidly evolving society as it was evident in Bobbitt's view. Today, I've come to recognize that the math curriculum I use to teach my students—something I once thought of as an apolitical subject—is, in fact, inherently political. This perspective is particularly evident from the Interpretivist-Experiential standpoint, and even more so from the Critical Praxeologist viewpoint.

The politicalization of the curriculum is evident in the work of Oliva and Gordon (2019), who articulate the increasing role that state education boards play in shaping curriculum by outlining goals and objectives. They note,

"States today, through their boards or departments of education, exert increasing leadership by promulgating statements of curriculum goals and, to a greater degree in recent years, statements of the aforementioned mission or visions, frameworks, standards or objectives, descriptors, and benchmarks" (p. 178).

From the States, the hierarchy flows down to the school-district,

"In practice, school districts and individual schools may accept the state's formulation of goals and objectives verbatim or, if the state permits, may independently develop their own statements. In either case, however, the statements of the school districts and individual schools must be in harmony with those of the state." (Oliva & Gordon, 2019, p. 179).

What stands out most from Oliva & Gordon is their statement: "As a general rule, the wishes of students, for example, should not hold the same priority as the beliefs of parents and other

laypeople" (2019, p. 183). While I appreciate the importance of having established standards to measure educational success, I question whether these standards serve the purpose of fostering a strong foundation in reasoning to address societal matters or merely prepare a workforce that supports an economic model rewarding those adept in mathematics, thereby disadvantaging those who are not. If the latter, then am I supporting a system that creates a "hidden curriculum" in the way I follow it?

In contrast to state boards that leave out the wishes of students in developing a curriculum, Dewey (1902) presents an Interpretivist Experiential view that emphasizes the significance of the child as an active learner. He critiques a system that arranges knowledge based on eternal and general truths, advocating for the acknowledgment of children's individual peculiarities and experiences. Dewey argues that education should not merely substitute children's natural whims with stable and well-ordered realities; rather, it should embrace their unique perspectives as essential components of learning. He states:

"Then studies introduce a world arranged on the basis of eternal and general truth; a world where all is measured and defined. Hence the moral: ignore and minimize the child's individual peculiarities, whims, and experiences. They are to be obscured or eliminated. As educators our work is precisely to substitute for these superficial and casual affairs stable and well-ordered realities; and these are found in studies and lessons" (p. 12).

By embracing children's individuality, educators can foster a more engaging and meaningful educational experience. While Dewey advocates for an education that prioritizes the individual experiences and active engagement of students, George S. Counts offers a critical perspective on the limitations of child-centered education. Counts argues that, despite its intentions, this approach often fails to address broader social issues and lacks a coherent theory of social welfare. He critiques child-centered education for its lack of progressiveness. In his review, he highlights a significant weakness of the movement: its absence of a coherent theory of social welfare at that time. Counts characterizes its supporters as "liberal-minded upper middle-class individuals who are relatively affluent," labeling them as "romantic sentimentalists" who cannot be trusted. He argues that Progressive Education was not genuinely progressive and, to free itself from the influence of this class, must confront "squarely and courageously every social issue." (G. Counts, 19##, p. 3)

Building on Counts' critique of child-centered education, Paulo Freire further challenges traditional educational paradigms by emphasizing the need to confront power dynamics within the classroom. Freire's work highlights the ways in which conventional teaching methods can

perpetuate oppression, reducing students to passive recipients of knowledge. He advocates for a more transformative approach to education that empowers students to become active participants in their learning and in the world around them. He critiques the current education system, stating that it has transformed students into "containers," "receptacles" to be "filled" by the teacher. He asserts, "The more completely she fills the receptacles, the better a teacher she is. The more meekly the receptacles permit themselves to be filled, the better the students they are." These words resonated deeply, as if he were describing Mr. Romero and his math class. Freire emphasizes that education is often seen as the act of depositing, with the teacher acting as the depositor.

"The more students work at storing the deposits entrusted to them, the less they develop the critical consciousness which would result from their intervention in the world as transformers of that world." (p. 73)

Having described the four Historical Curricular-Pedagogical then we have the question, from them what should we retain? From the Traditionalist praxis, we should retain the quest for deepness in each subject that is taught. From the Positivist we should emphasize the use of the scientific method to create goals and objectives that fit the aim of educations. From the Interpretivists-Experiential we should maintain that the child comes with experiences that should be relevant to their learning. From the Critical Praxeologist, we should highlight that the old model of learning where students are merely receptacles of information only serves to reinforce the status quo limiting their capacity for critical thinking and active participation in their own education.

References

- Counts, G. (1932). Dare progressive education be progressive? [Speech]. *Progressive Education*, 9(4), 257–263.
- Oliva, P. & Gordon, W. R. (2019). Ch 8 Curriculum goals, objectives, and products. *Developing the curriculum* (p. 172-196). Pearson.
- Dewey, J. (1902). *The child and the curriculum*. University of Chicago.